

# St. Joseph the All-Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

Number 14, April 28, ns, Holy Wednesday 2021

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Note: With God helping us, we will send many newsletters to all those we minister to in prison. We aim to send a newsletter at least twice each month. This is the 14<sup>th</sup> sent to 80 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at <http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

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**NOTE: Fr. David manages our ministry's distribution of Orthodox books, church calendars, icons, and service texts. Contact him if you need anything.**

## Questions About Bright Week

- QUESTION 1** What is and when does Bright Week begin and end?  
**QUESTION 2** How many days are in Bright Week? There are TWO correct answers!  
**QUESTION 3** What is the fasting typicon during Bright week?  
**QUESTION 4** What pious tradition is there concerning the marriage bed during Bright week and why?  
**QUESTION 5** What feast is celebrated Bright Friday?  
**QUESTION 6** What are the normal morning and evening prayers during Bright week?

- QUESTION 7** What very common prayer do we NOT say during Bright Week and a long while thereafter, and then begin saying again after another feast?  
**QUESTION 8** What liturgical book contains all the changeable parts of vespers and matins for Bright week? During what period is this book used (besides bright week)?  
**QUESTION 9** What are some of the dangers of Bright week?  
**QUESTION 10** Describe the main differences between Vespers during Bright week and regular vespers.

**Don't cheat! Try to answer the questions. Some of the articles in the newsletter may help you. The answers are at the end. No peeking!**

## Prison Ministry News

We own the building in Marshall now! The next item on the agenda is to have someone who is not on parole, which is acceptable to the TDCJ powers, to live there full-time so that we can allow one parolee at a time to come. This might seem very small and pitiful to you, but frequently great

things begin in very humble ways. Remember the oak tree! It grows from a tiny acorn. We have an idea about getting a resident. We will keep you posted. We want to keep this house an Orthodox house, so unless we are forced to, we don't want to have residents there that are not Orthodox.

Our understanding is that because of the location of the building, any person can parole there no matter what their offense. We also understand that we cannot have more than one parolee at a time. We might test that rule and see if we get lucky. We might attempt to be something like a halfway house if we can find a lawyer to do pro bono work, however we don't want TDCJ to send us just anybody. We want to be very selective for your sake and for ours.

We intend to build a chapel there and actually operate a bona fide parish named after St. Joseph the all Comely. Fr. David and Fr. Seraphim

### A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life – 56-58

56. Partake as frequently as possible of the Holy, Life-Giving Mysteries of the Body and Blood of our Lord Jesus Christ, with faith, compunction, and a contrite heart. Only through the Holy Eucharist can you know true life.

57. Never forget the Divine judgment and requital are at hand.

will travel there, hopefully once a month each. At least Fr. Seraphim will plan on traveling there once a month. Father David is doing all the prison traveling right now. So, Fr. Seraphim will definitely travel there once a month and maybe twice.

Pray for this endeavor. All you need to do is do a prostration and say Lord Jesus Christ have mercy upon St. Joseph's prison ministry. God knows everything that we need and everything that you need, and may it be that when we are supplied the things we need so that we can supply you with the things you need.

58. Remember also everything beautiful that the Lord has prepared for those who love Him, and keep His commandments.

Fr Alexander's closing words: Dear brothers and sisters in Christ, most of us are far from even beginning to fulfill these precepts; nevertheless, accept from me, sinful Aleksandr, this Primer of Spiritual Life..

### A word from Fr Seraphim

Christ is risen! My ambition is to mail this newsletter on Holy Wednesday, for/28. The newsletter is very late, and I beg your forgiveness. There may be some typos, and I hope they are not too funny or strange because I'm trying to do this all in a rush. I have started sending one very large newsletter a month. It saves us money, and you get more articles because with one envelope, I can use a regular stamp and a \$0.20 stamp and send you ten double-sided pages, for a total of 20 pages. With a single stamp, I can only send (safely), eight double sided pages, which is only 16 pages. We get more bang for our buck! And still this past month, for the first time since the newsletter has been started we didn't send you anything in the month. This is entirely my fault. Fr. David tells me that he sent you some things about Pascha and his greeting. He definitely has a better secretary than I do!

I hope that you get this newsletter before Pascha, but in any case, you'll get it during Bright week, and if you read this newsletter carefully, you will know that Bright week is during Pascha. Because Pascha is the feast of feasts, this newsletter is entirely about Pascha and the Paschal period except for the standard stuff that we do at the beginning. There are some articles which are about Sundays which occurred during the Pascha, such as Thomas Sunday and the Sunday of the Myrrh Bearers. They all focus on a theme. I hope you can see it clearly.

Does life move very fast for you? It does for me. I never get everything done. I've learned that the most important thing that I can do is pray, and I do much more of that than I did years ago. I want you to profit from my mistakes, and increase your prayer now and not wait until later! I hope that you all know this –the most important thing you can do whether you are in prison or at home or an astronaut flying to Jupiter- is pray.

We cannot be Christians if we do not pray. We must pray much more than just a few things from the prayer book haphazardly or even regularly. Pray for those you care about. These not only include our family and those that are friends, but also our enemies. You should definitely care about your enemies. God uses your enemies to help you gain your salvation. Our enemies test our humility, and our patience and our resolve. Since we should be praying for our enemies, our enemies teach us to love when it is difficult to love. If you do not pray for your enemies, but you hate them or you don't want to think about them, or you speak poorly of them, then you have not learned how to be a Christian yet. At least pray for your enemies! It is difficult to think kindly of them in the beginning and it is impossible to think kindly of them if we do not pray. You can at least pray for them, even if it is through clenched teeth!

Do you like rigor? I have learned to love it. There is a lot of rigor in prison. Most of it is being told to do pointless, and often uncomfortable and even

painful things, or doing without, such as not having commissary for no good reason at all or being locked down for no good reason at all. All of the hardness teaches us to love God.

There will be less rigor during the Paschal period, but do not forget asceticism! The most essential asceticism and the asceticism which gives birth to all other ascetical acts is that we learn to deny ourselves and struggle to love people as God loves them.

If you usually do prostrations, I recommend that you stop doing them during Bright week but then go back to them. We won't do any prostrations in the church until the day of Pentecost, but going 50 days without doing prostrations and praying for your loved ones is too long! You can keep doing your prostrations even during Bright week. You can also keep saying the prayer of St. Ephrem if you wish. It's really a perfect prayer isn't it?

By the way, if you're not doing prostrations, you're doing it wrong. You already know how to suffer and to do without because you're in prison. But that kind of suffering won't gain you the kingdom. The only suffering which gains you the kingdom is when you voluntarily suffer for the sake of God and, of course, since God loves everyone, for others, even the ones that might appear to you to be undeserving.

I want to tell you a few things about the vaccines being promoted with ever-present propaganda. The literature for the vaccines states clearly that they are experimental drugs, and not official vaccines yet, and they are not designed to prevent you from getting Covid! Most people think that a vaccine keeps you from getting the disease. This one does not! Of course, it is not promoted as such. The promise of these drugs is that if you get Covid you will not have a serious case. It is a promise which anecdotal evidence shows is often unfulfilled. The side effects of these vaccines are not being discussed except among those who are not "woke". I happen to have a doctor in my parish and also access to other medical people who really know what's going on.

Even if you do not have medical misgivings about this therapy, I want you to know that all vaccines currently being offered in the United States have been developed or tested with cell lines from aborted fetal cells. They are part of the culture of death. You might hear many stories about the cells that I absolutely guarantee to you that they are from aborted fetuses. There is a story, which, if you believe, I would like to sell you a part of the Brooklyn Bridge, that these abortions were "one-offs" and will never happen again. This is already not true, but it is said so often that people really believe it. Medical science has come to dependence on aborted fetal tissue and fetal organs for research. Pandora's box has been opened, and it's not closing anytime soon.

I personally will not take the vaccine even if that means that I will be not allowed to go to prison or get onto an airplane. That will mean a great loss for me because I will never see you in prison again, and for those that I go to Africa to see, but this is how strongly I feel about this vaccine. It remains to be seen whether or not I have the strength to maintain this resolve. I expect persecution of those who will not take the vaccine. I just heard of one occurrence recently. The father was not allowed to go into his wife who had just given birth because neither one of them was vaccinated. They were told that he could be with her if they both were vaccinated. The remarkably stupid thing about this attempt to make them comply is that even if they were vaccinated that day, the vaccine would not be effective in any way whatsoever until at least four weeks later. Therefore, whether they are vaccinated or not, they are not less dangerous to the hospital. This is an attempt to make people comply. You will see more of it. You may also be persecuted. Of course, they cannot put you in prison for it, but they can certainly make your life more difficult.

Everyone must make their own decision about whether or not they take the vaccines. I recommend highly against it for medical reasons but most especially for moral reasons. If you've already taken the vaccine don't fret about it, but understand that the things that are being said about it in the mainstream media are not altogether true. If you have the strength to refuse the vaccine, then may that be blessed. If you take the vaccine, then I would recommend that you would offer something to God, such as praying

for all women who have had abortions or that God would deliver us from the unbelief that is so prevalent in our society.

I sincerely apologize to those of you who have written me personally, sometimes many times, and I've not replied. I definitely intend to do so, but life is very hectic. Our parish is growing by leaps and bounds because we're the only ones that have normal services in the area. Both Fr. Nicholas and I are incredibly busy. Some people are coming because they just don't want to wear a mask but a significant number of people are coming because they feel that the Gospel they are being preached by their pastors by their reaction to Covid is a false gospel. There are actually churches that require masks unless you been vaccinated (and this for a supposed vaccine that actually tells us does not prevent infection with Covid!). They approve of all vaccines. And they make people stand apart and wear masks and all the rest. Some churches in the area use multiple spoons or disinfect the spoon after each communicant.

We are trying to live as we have always lived. It might be that there will come a time when the government tries to force us to live in a certain way. May we have strength to make the right choices.

I know many of you on the mailing list for this newsletter and some of you I do not know, but please know that I pray for each of you every day. I do not ignore that duty, and it's the most important one that I can fulfill for you.

May God bless you and help you in all things! Unworthy priest Seraphim.

### Pascha in "Dachau 1945: The Souls of All Are Aflame"



By Douglas Cramer

*In 1945, a Paschal Liturgy like no other was performed. Just days after their liberation by the US military on April 29, 1945, hundreds of Orthodox Christian prisoners at the Dachau concentration camp gathered to celebrate the Resurrection service and to give thanks.*

The Dachau concentration camp was opened in 1933 in a former gunpowder factory. The first prisoners interred there were political opponents of Adolf Hitler, who had become German chancellor that same year. During the twelve years of the camp's existence, over 200,000 prisoners were brought there. The majority of prisoners at Dachau were Christians, including Protestant, Roman Catholic, and Orthodox clergy and lay people.

Countless prisoners died at Dachau, and hundreds were forced to participate in the cruel medical experiments conducted by [Dr. Sigmund Rascher](#). When prisoners arrived at the camp they were beaten, insulted, shorn of their hair, and had all their belongings taken from them. The SS guards could kill whenever they thought it was appropriate. Punishments included being hung on hooks for hours, high enough that heels did not touch the ground; being stretched on trestles; being whipped with soaked leather whips; and being placed in solitary confinement for days on end in rooms too small to lie down in.

The abuse of the prisoners reached its end in the spring of 1945. The events of that Holy Week were later recorded by one of the prisoners, Gleb Rahr. Rahr grew up in Latvia and fled with his family to Nazi Germany when the Russians invaded. He was arrested by the Gestapo because of his membership in an organization that opposed both fascism and communism. Originally imprisoned in Buchenwald, he was transported to Dachau near the end of the war.

In fact, Rahr was one of the survivors of the infamous "death trains," as they were called by the American G.I.'s who discovered them. Thousands of prisoners from different camps had been sent to Dachau in open rail cars. The vast majority of them died horrific deaths from starvation, dehydration, exposure, sickness, and execution.

In a letter to his parents the day after the liberation, G.I. William Cowling wrote, "As we crossed the track and looked back into the cars the most horrible sight I have ever seen met my eyes. The cars were loaded with dead bodies. Most of them were naked and all of them skin and bones. Honest their legs and arms were only a couple of inches around and they had no buttocks at all. Many of the bodies had bullet holes in the back of their heads."

Marcus Smith, one of the US Army personnel assigned to Dachau, also described the scene in his 1972 book, [The Harrowing of Hell](#).

Refuse and excrement are spread over the cars and grounds. More of the dead lie near piles of clothing, shoes, and trash. Apparently some had crawled or fallen out of the cars when the doors were opened, and died on the grounds. One of our men counts the boxcars and says that there are thirty-nine. Later I hear that there were fifty, that the train had arrived at the camp during the evening of April 27, by which time all of the passengers were supposed to be dead so that the bodies could be disposed of in the camp crematorium. But this could not be done because there was no more coal to stoke the furnaces. Mutilated bodies of German soldiers are also on the ground, and occasionally we see an inmate scream at the body of his former tormentor and kick it. Retribution!

Rahr was one of the over 4,000 Russian prisoners at Dachau at the time of the liberation. The liberated prisoners also included over 1,200 Christian clergymen. After the war, Rahr immigrated to the United States, where he taught Russian History at the University of Maryland. He later worked for Radio Free Europe. His account of the events at Dachau in 1945 begins with his arrival at the camp:

April 27th: The last transport of prisoners arrives from Buchenwald. Of the 5,000 originally destined for Dachau, I was among the 1,300 who had survived the trip. Many were shot, some starved to death, while others died of typhus ...

April 28th: I and my fellow prisoners can hear the bombardment of Munich taking place some 30 km from our concentration camp. As the sound of artillery approaches ever nearer from the west and the north, orders are given proscribing prisoners from leaving their barracks under any circumstances. SS-soldiers patrol the camp on motorcycles as machine guns are directed at us from the watch-towers, which surround the camp ...

April 29th: The booming sound of artillery has been joined by the staccato bursts of machine gun fire. Shells whistle over the camp from all directions. Suddenly white flags appear on the towers—a sign of hope that the SS would surrender rather than shoot all prisoners and fight to the last man. Then, at about 6:00 p.m., a strange sound can be detected emanating from somewhere near the camp gate which swiftly increases in volume ...

The sound came from the dawning recognition of freedom. Lt. Col. Walter Fellenz of the US Seventh Army described the greeting from his point of view:

Several hundred yards inside the main gate, we encountered the concentration enclosure, itself. There before us, behind an electrically charged, barbed wire fence, stood a mass of cheering, half-mad men, women and children, waving and shouting with happiness—their liberators had come! The noise was beyond comprehension! Every individual (over 32,000) who could utter a sound, was cheering. Our hearts wept as we saw the tears of happiness fall from their cheeks.

Rahr's account continues :Finally all 32,600 prisoners join in the cry as the first American soldiers appear just behind the wire fence of the camp. After a short while electric power is turned off, the gates open and the American G.I.'s make their entrance. As they stare wide-eyed at our lot, half-starved as we are and suffering from typhus and dysentery, they appear more like fifteen-year-old boys than battle-weary soldiers ...

An international committee of prisoners is formed to take over the administration of the camp. Food from SS stores is put at the disposal of the camp kitchen. A US military unit also contributes some provision, thereby providing me with my first opportunity to taste American corn. By order of an American officer radio-receivers are confiscated from prominent Nazis in the town of Dachau and distributed to the various national groups of prisoners. The news comes in: Hitler has committed suicide, the Russians have taken Berlin, and German troops have surrendered in the South and in the North. But the fighting still rages in Austria and Czechoslovakia ...

Naturally, I was ever cognizant of the fact that these momentous events were unfolding during Holy Week. But how could we mark it, other than through our silent, individual prayers? A fellow-prisoner and chief interpreter of the International Prisoner's Committee, Boris F., paid a visit to my typhus-infested barrack — "Block 27" — to inform me that efforts were

underway in conjunction with the Yugoslav and Greek National Prisoner's Committees to arrange an Orthodox service for Easter day, May 6th.

There were Orthodox priests, deacons, and a group of monks from Mount Athos among the prisoners. But there were no vestments, no books whatsoever, no icons, no candles, no prosphoras, no wine ... Efforts to acquire all these items from the Russian church in Munich failed, as the Americans just could not locate anyone from that parish in the devastated city. Nevertheless, some of the problems could be solved. The approximately four hundred Catholic priests detained in Dachau had been allowed to remain together in one barrack and recite mass every morning before going to work. They offered us Orthodox the use of their prayer room in "Block 26," which was just across the road from my own "block."

The chapel was bare, save for a wooden table and a Czenstochowa icon of the Theotokos hanging on the wall above the table—an icon which had originated in Constantinople and was later brought to Belz in Galicia, where it was subsequently taken from the Orthodox by a Polish king. When the Russian Army drove Napoleon's troops from Czenstochowa, however, the abbot of the Czenstochowa Monastery gave a copy of the icon to czar Alexander I, who placed it in the Kazan Cathedral in Saint-Petersburg where it was venerated until the Bolshevik seizure of power. A creative solution to the problem of the vestments was also found. New linen towels were taken from the hospital of our former SS-guards. When sewn together lengthwise, two towels formed an epitrichion and when sewn together at the ends they became an orarion. Red crosses, originally intended to be worn by the medical personnel of the SS guards, were put on the towel-vestments.

On Easter Sunday, May 6th (April 23rd according to the Church calendar)—which ominously fell that year on Saint George the Victory-Bearer's Day—Serbs, Greeks and Russians gathered at the Catholic priests' barracks. Although Russians comprised about 40 percent of the Dachau inmates, only a few managed to attend the service. By that time "repatriation officers" of the special Smersh units had arrived in Dachau by American military planes, and begun the process of erecting new lines of barbed wire for the purpose of isolating Soviet citizens from the rest of the prisoners, which was the first step in preparing them for their eventual forced repatriation.

In the entire history of the Orthodox Church there has probably never been an Easter service like the one at Dachau in 1945. Greek and Serbian priests together with a Serbian deacon wore the make-shift "vestments" over their blue and gray-striped prisoner's uniforms. Then they began to chant, changing from Greek to Slavonic, and then back again to Greek. The Easter Canon, the Easter Sticheras—everything was recited from memory. The Gospel—"In the beginning was the Word"—also from memory.

And finally, the Homily of Saint John Chrysostom—also from memory. A young Greek monk from the Holy Mountain stood up in front of us and recited it with such infectious enthusiasm that we shall never forget him as long as we live. Saint John Chrysostomos himself seemed to speak through him to us and to the rest of the world as well! Eighteen Orthodox priests and one deacon—most of whom were Serbs—participated in this unforgettable service. Like the sick man who had been lowered through the roof of a house and placed in front of the feet of Christ the Savior, the Greek Archimandrite Meletios was carried on a stretcher into the chapel, where he remained prostrate for the duration of the service.

Other prisoners at Dachau included the recently canonized Bishop Nikolai Velimirovich, who later became the first administrator of the Serbian Orthodox Church in the US and Canada; and the Very Reverend Archimandrite Dionysios, who after the war was made Metropolitan of Trikkis and Stagnon in Greece.

Fr. Dionysios had been arrested in 1942 for giving asylum to an English officer fleeing the Nazis. He was tortured for not revealing the names of others involved in aiding Allied soldiers and was then imprisoned for eighteen months in Thessalonica before being transferred to Dachau. During his two years at Dachau, he witnessed Nazi atrocities and suffered greatly himself. He recorded many harrowing experiences in his book "Ieroi Palmoi." Among these were regular marches to the firing squad, where he would be spared at the last moment, ridiculed, and then returned to the destitution of the prisoners' block.

After the liberation, Fr. Dionysios helped the Allies to relocate former Dachau inmates and to bring some normalcy to their disrupted lives. Before his death, Metropolitan Dionysios returned to Dachau from Greece and celebrated the first peacetime Orthodox Liturgy there. Writing in 1949, Fr. Dionysios remembered Pascha 1945 in these words:

In the open air, behind the shanty, the Orthodox gather together, Greeks and Serbs. In the center, both priests, the Serb and the Greek. They aren't wearing golden vestments. They don't even have cassocks. No tapers, no service books in their hands. But now they don't need external, material lights to hymn the joy. The souls of all are aflame, swimming in light.

Blessed is our God. My little paper-bound New Testament has come into its glory. We chant "Christ is Risen" many times, and its echo reverberates everywhere and sanctifies this place.

Hitler's Germany, the tragic symbol of the world without Christ, no longer exists. And the hymn of the life of faith was going up from all the souls; the life that proceeds buoyantly toward the Crucified One of the verdant hill of Stein.



Russian Orthodox Memorial Chapel at Dachau

Here is a comment in the article cited. M. Stankovich says [April 20, 2017 at 10:16 AM](#)

My father was a captured Serbian military officer who spent the last 18-months of the war at Dachau, among a group of officers who made it their mission to protect St. Nikolai Velimirovich. Some brought a mouthful of absconded wine from the staff kitchen where they worked so St. Nikolai could occasionally serve a liturgy, alone and hidden, and accompany him as he took the Eucharist as many as he could. My mother read me and my brother fairy tales at bedtime (Baba Yaga was her favorite!), but when my father put us to bed, we would beg him to tell us his stories of the "concentration camp," where he depicted their captors as buffoons, inept, and easily tricked. The only hints of the reality were his jokes, e.g. "five potatoes to 50-gallons of water,

and they called it potato soup.” He never spoke of atrocity, cruelty, or “crimes against humanity,” but my brother and I never forgot his lifetime of tortured sleep – punctuated by thrashing, shouting, and what he simply described as “bad dreams.” It strikes me that in commemorating “all Orthodox Christians who lost their lives at this place,” we must also commemorate those who “survived,” but who lost their “lives” as they once knew it.

This was heartbreaking to read, but I thank you for providing this account of the Orthodox Christians who were the largely forgotten victims of these crimes that called out to heaven. Memory Eternal.

Christ is risen! What is the meaning of Pascha?

Holy Week, 2017



What is the meaning of Pascha? Why is it the feast of feasts? Many people do not know, and because of this, this is the hardest week of the year for me. It is not because of services twice a day for 2 weeks, or the other things that may make me physically tired. It is because we are preparing to celebrate the redemption of the human race, and grace will be given liberally to all, but many do not “get it”. They are concerned with getting their Pascha basket blessed, or coming late at night to the one service they attend all year, or having communion with no preparation, or self-inspection, or fasting, or desire to be transformed from death to life. I will say things from my heart to them, and some will have blank faces, and be unmoved. Joy is not full unless it is shared, fully, by everyone. So, my joy is always tempered because not everyone who holds a candle and brings a basket to church knows the meaning of Pascha, and orders their entire life by it.

**I want you to be “moved” by Pascha. I want it to change EVERYTHING in your life.**

What are we celebrating on Pascha? The word means “Passover”, and we use it to refer to the Resurrection of our Lord and Savior, the God-man, Jesus Christ, instead of that silly, untheological word which is derived from the name of a Babylonian fertility god.

Jesus Christ is our Passover, the final Passover. There is no need for another Passover because He conquered sin and death for us. He took on our humanity, which was broken and inclined to sin, and unable to be in the

presence of God because of our impurity. There is a beautiful hymn, which I recently gave a homily about<sup>1</sup>. I will reproduce it here. It explains what happened in the incarnation:

Today is revealed the mystery hidden from before time began,  
and the Son of God becometh the Son of man,  
that, taking upon Himself that which is below Him,  
He might bestow upon me that which is more sublime.

Of old Adam was deceived, and, desiring to become a god, he failed;

but God becometh man, that He might make Adam a god.

Let creation be glad! Let nature dance!

For the archangel standeth in fear before the Virgin and offereth her his “Rejoice!”, the antidote to grief.

O our God Who art become man in the lovingkindness of Thy mercy, glory be to Thee!

(Doxasticon for the feast of Annunciation, the composition of Theophanes, in Tone II)

The “mystery” is God, and His plan to create us in His image, and to give us Himself as a gift – for us to share in His knowledge and purity and perfection – to have union with Him. Another mystery is how we sin so easily, and this sin makes it impossible for us to reach perfection (even if the sin is forgiven, because sin fundamentally corrupts our nature).

The Son of God became man to make human nature better, and make it capable of perfect life. This is expressed by saying that He made Adam “a god”. This is scriptural. It is in the Psalms, and was even quoted by Christ<sup>2</sup>. God is totally free. We were made to be totally free – to always be ABLE to choose good, and not even desire anything evil, and to know the hidden things of God, which are only revealed to the pure in heart. This is what it means to be a “god”. This is the meaning of the “Rejoice!” in the hymn. This is a very big Rejoice! - a mysterious Rejoice! Because of the incarnation, man, who is held fast by sin and cannot know God, can be freed from sin and death, and become a god!

The Protestants do not understand what Jesus did. Most think that He took on a punishment intended for us, because “the wages of sin is death”, and by dying instead of us, he appeased God’s righteous justice and anger. This is bizarre.

He came that we “might have life, and might have it abundantly.” He came to lead us from darkness to light. He came so that the broken things in our nature would be fixed. That is what the hymn above is teaching, in the lines:

” ...that, taking upon Himself that which is **below** [human nature, full of sin] Him, He might bestow upon me that which is **more sublime** [that man may be forgiven his sin, eradicate his sin, and become a god].”



The greatest tragedy of human existence was the sin of Adam and Eve. That sin polluted human nature, and made it impossible for anyone to reach perfection. However, we were born for perfection! How could it be otherwise, since the Holy Trinity stated plainly His intentions when He

created man: “Let us make man in our own image”<sup>3</sup>. God is perfect, and holy, and free. If we are made in His image then we must be like Him since we all know that a parent brings forth a child who is like him.

Sin is slavery. It is the exact opposite of freedom. Jesus Christ came to save us from sin. To do this, He became one of us and changed our nature so that we could conquer sin and death. He did not die in our place – he died so that death would die! We say this plainly in the Paschal Troparion, which we sing hundreds of times in the Paschal season:

**“Christ is risen from the dead, trampling down death by death, and upon those in the tombs, bestowing life!”**

It is impossible to feel Pascha in the heart *without* feeling death. Only those who know the purpose and meaning of their life and are aware of their sins and struggle against them with all of their strength can feel Pascha.

We are creatures who do things that are “dead”. Sin is dead. Anger is dead. Lust is dead. We should have a deep longing in our heart to put away all things in our life that are dead. Those things are cold, and dark. God is warm, and He is light. With baptism, we are made capable of becoming all warmth and all light, with no coldness or darkness in us at all. This is because Jesus Christ conquered darkness and coldness – death.

On Pascha, we do not celebrate a historical event, but an ongoing reality that is unfolding within ourselves. The Lord said as He was beginning His ministry that “the Kingdom of heaven is within you”<sup>4</sup>. We are coming closer to the full understanding of this reality every day – but only if we struggle to follow the commandments.

I invite you to join me in celebrating and praising God, that our darkness will not remain darkness, and our cold hearts do not remain cold, and our sins will not only be blotted out but that we will increase in knowledge and purity such that we will not sin or desire to sin.

This is the meaning of Pascha. **Christ is risen! Truly He is risen!**

I covet your prayers. I am always treading water, but I want to swim! I pray for everybody I see in the parish and in my prison ministry, and a good deal more that I no longer see, for known and unknown reasons, every day. Please remember me in your prayers.

In Christ,

Unworthy Priest Seraphim, who prays for you his unworthy prayers.

**As Many as have been baptized into Christ have put on Christ. Why is this sung on Pascha?**

A short Homily delivered on Pascha.

I must say a few words on this holy day, not too many, because the hour is late, and we're not accustomed to praying late at night. Tonight, brothers, and sisters, I wish to bring you one word. We sang just a moment ago, “As many have been baptized into Christ have put on Christ.” This is sung at several great feasts, preeminently Pascha. Why do we sing this hymn today? What does it have to do with Pascha?

Look at the example of the apostles and all the Saints. For them, the Lord's resurrection, with the subsequent giving of the Holy Spirit, ENABLES them to become like the Lord in virtue! This is the meaning of Pascha! Now we are ABLE to live, ABLE to know God, ABLE to become sweet. Without our Lord

living as a man, and breaking the hold death held on the flesh, we would not be able to live, truly be alive, and be in Christ, that is, put on Christ.

He broke much more that Hades hold on us after this life. His Resurrection heals us now, enables us to attain to the knowledge of Him, and as the Apostle says today - to become sons of God.

This is only possible by putting on Christ. If you do not do this by intense struggle, the stone at your tomb will not be rolled away, and there will be no resurrection in it's cold, dark contents.

Put on Christ! Live like Him! Struggle to live virtuously. Put away evil and do good, knowing that all this is possible because Christ did all these things

as a man, and therefore we can too, and His Resurrection breaks any hold death has on our flesh in this life or the next, if we only live!

## Two Healings on Pascha

What is it that we celebrate, brothers and sisters, what do we celebrate today? We celebrate two healings: the God-man, with His two natures - a son twice - healed us of **death and sin**. And if you read this Gospel carefully, it speaks of this - not openly, but in a way that is mystical and spiritual.

Now, we all know that Jesus Christ rose from the dead. His rising from the dead made our flesh able to become pure. And to the pure, all things are pure, as it says in the scriptures. If we become purified with the help of God, because now we're capable of becoming this, we will know God. Not only will we know God, but we will become sons of God.

Now really, death and sin are two sides of the same coin: where there is death, there is darkness, and sin also darkens the soul. No one can be happy when their soul is darkened with sin, and inevitably, sin brings about death. But the Lord broke this cycle where man is born, and inevitably He sins, and inevitably He dies, and is not able to see God, because our Lord lived as God and man, If He was only begotten of the father, He always knew God as God's son: eternally, but, as a man, and He had to make His flesh invigorated so that it could see God.

We can appropriate this great salvation. Now how do we appropriate it? St. John says as many as received Him, to them He gave the power to become sons of God, even to them that believe on His name, which were born not of blood nor of the will of the flesh nor of the will of man but of God.

Brothers and sisters if you want to truly feel the Resurrection, if you want to have joy that cannot be taken away from you, then you must receive

Christ. And what is this receiving? The Lord gives us commandments, perfect and wonderful commandments; His yoke is easy and His burden is light, and He desires us to follow these commandments and He makes us capable of following these commandments; and if we struggle to follow them, it is a certainty that the Lord will make His abode with us and we will be happy. This is a happiness that the world doesn't know, a happiness that never ever grows old.

This is what we celebrate on Pascha, that we can become complete, we can become whole, we can become perfected, we can have absolute happiness, for eternity, knowing God.

But the Lord didn't just break the bonds of death: He broke the bonds of sin too, because as a man He lived without sin. He was like us in all things. He was tempted in all ways, just as any other man would be tempted, except that He did not sin. So He made our flesh change, just as the old covenant changed into the new, the old man, who would live in sin and die and go into the grave, was changed into the new man, who would live, and would be capable - if He would receive Christ, of living righteously, and when He dies, He would not die the death of eternal damnation, but He would be alive in Christ. This is what the Resurrection does for us: it makes us able to see God.

Glory be to God that He has given us so many blessings. He's given us grace and truth and grace for grace. May God help you live righteously so that you can feel in every aspect of your life the presence of God and joy. Amen.

## Why do we read from the beginning of John on the night of Pascha?

### To live in the Resurrection, we must know Jesus Christ.

#### Pascha 2010 John 1:1-17

In the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit, Amen.  
Christ is risen! TRULY HE IS RISEN  
Christos Anesti! ALITHOS ANESTI!  
Christos Voskrese! VOISTINU VOSKRESE!

Brothers and sisters, on this bright day of the Resurrection of the Lord Jesus Christ, we read from the beginning of the Gospel of John, which does not say anything about Resurrection. There are many passages in the Gospels that speak about the Resurrection; we read eleven of them in a cycle throughout the year in matins, but we did not read this time about the Resurrection. We read about it this morning, but not this evening.

Now why is this, that on the very day when we most extravagantly celebrate the Resurrection we read from the beginning of John and not a resurrection story?

Well, we certainly know about the Resurrection, but have we lived it yet? Who is the Resurrection? – Jesus Christ. Saint John, preeminently, of all the Apostles and Evangelists, shows us Who Jesus Christ is. In order for the Resurrection to be actualized in our life, we must know Jesus Christ. So it is apropos that from this day forward, during the cycle of Pascha, for forty days an onwards - forty days after Pascha is the Ascension and fifty days after is Pentecost – we read from the Gospel of John because we are to learn of Jesus Christ, the One who is meek and lowly, the One Who came to save us from our sins.

Just knowing this does not make it happen – we must live according to Who Jesus Christ is. The joy of the Resurrection is that we can become completely alive, completely human, as we are meant to be. Right now, brothers and sisters, we are in a state that is between human and not human. God created us to know Him perfectly and intimately. Since we do not, we are not quite what we should be. But the joy of the Resurrection is that we can become this.

Jesus Christ became like us in all things except for sin. And He lived on this earth as a man and also fully as God, having two natures, not intermixed, but cooperating with one-another. And His human nature is as ours should be. It was as ours in all things except sin, even to the point that it would die, because we know that our Lord died on the cross.

But then a wondrous thing happened. Of His own power, of His Divinity – the hymns of Holy Saturday especially sing of it – the one Who created the universe, Who laid dead in tomb, became alive of His own power.

And He imbued humanity with the ability to be alive too. This is what we are celebrating, brothers and sisters! We are not celebrating merely the event of Christ rising from the dead; we are celebrating that reality that WE can rise from the dead.

And make no mistake – this is not a future event for us. The Lord made that perfectly clear, when He began preaching and said that “The kingdom of heaven is within you.”

So right now, brothers and sisters, we should live according to the Resurrection, in everything. And as we live in this light, we become light; we become peaceful.

Now let's be honest with ourselves: there is a lot in us that is not peaceful; there is a lot in us that is not light. But God came so that we could be ALL LIGHT. That is what we are celebrating today. He resurrected Himself so that we could become resurrected. For Him, it happened in a flash, in a moment. For us it happens in a lifetime, with struggle, with difficulties, with happiness, sadness, holiness, and with depravity – all the things that are mixed up in our complex nature.

But I tell you, God's nature is not complex – He is only good. And that is what we are to become – simple and only good. And our Lord Jesus Christ, although he was man, was simple, because as man, and as God, He was only good. And He made us capable of becoming good, and fully human.

This is what we celebrate today, and this is why we start reading the Gospel of John today – because you cannot know the Resurrection unless you know Jesus Christ. It is not possible. And there is only one way to know Jesus Christ – to become like Him. That is what we are called to do. And the great joy is that it is possible – God came so we could become like Him. This is what we celebrate today, brothers and sisters.

Anything that you do in your life, no matter what it is, no matter how small or how large, no matter how long it takes, or if it is just for a moment – if it is according to the Resurrection, then it will bring you light. Anything that you do that is not according to the Resurrection only brings darkness.

It really is that simple. Certainly we live in a complex life, with complex decisions to make about things and difficulties that we are perplexed about – this is true. But basically life is – choose good and avoid evil. Not because the Lord commands, but because it is the only way to have life. So we celebrate today that we can have life.

Brothers and sisters, this life is in knowing our Lord Jesus Christ; that is why we read the Gospel of John.

After a feast, the church will have hymns that discuss the feast in a deeper way. You will see this all throughout the whole period of Pascha. All

the Gospels for Sunday are about the gradual enlightenment of man, because the Resurrection occurs in us bit by bit. You can see it how it happened to the women, to the apostles. At first they could not believe, at first they were afraid. At first the Apostles thought that the words of the women who announced the Resurrection were nonsense. Thomas could not believe for eight days. Peter could not have the joy of the Resurrection until the risen Lord told them to go fishing and then He restored him after they caught many fish.

This is the way life is, brothers and sisters. It takes time to be enlightened; it takes effort to be enlightened. And the church will speak of it over the next forty and fifty days. So the Gospel of John is sort of the prelude to all that.

The church IS Jesus Christ. All truth is Jesus Christ. The truth is not an abstract concept; truth is a person – Jesus Christ. So when you say that you live according to the truth that means that you are becoming like Christ. The Gospel of John teaches us preeminently Who Jesus Christ is, but it cannot be learned just by reading – it can only be learned by ... becoming.

So let us celebrate today that we can become like as God; we can become light, with no darkness in us at all; we can become arisen, with no death in us at all. This is what we were created for, and this is what we celebrate.

Christ is risen! TRULY HE IS RISEN

Christos Anesti! ALITHOS ANESTI!

Christos Voskrese! VOISTINU VOSKRESE!

May God bless you and help you to live in the light of the Resurrection.

Priest Seraphim Holland 2010

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sunday-01\\_2010-04-04.doc](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sunday-01_2010-04-04.doc)

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sunday-01\\_2010-04-04.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sunday-01_2010-04-04.mp3)  
(AUDIO)

## Sunday of Pascha Agape vespers: Paschal instructions

|                    |                    |
|--------------------|--------------------|
| Christ is risen!   | Truly He is risen! |
| Christos aneste!   | Alithos aneste!    |
| Christos Voskrese! | Voistinu voskrese! |

I want to tell you a few things about this week. This week is as one day, according to the Typicon. It is as if Pascha is an entire week. So for that reason we don't fast today, nor do we fast tomorrow or Tuesday or Wednesday or Thursday or Friday or Saturday or Sunday. No fasting for the entire week. All foods are allowed. Tofu is forbidden. Even bean, you know the bean hamburger things, they're forbidden. Okay? They are like anathema. All foods are allowed for this week.

Also, now, during this week we say Paschal hours for our prayers instead of morning and evening prayers. We don't read the Psalter at all. If you saw in the service, the only verses of the Psalter used were when we were singing the Stichera. The penitential verses of the Psalter are not read. We don't read Psalm 50 the entire week. We don't read Psalm 118 which is normally read every day. We don't read any of the Psalter except the portions that are for the Prokeimena or for the "Lord I have cried."

So the Paschal hours<sup>5</sup> are in your prayer book whether it is an English one or in Slavonic. Use these Paschal hours; it takes about six minutes to sing them, maybe five and a half minutes to read them; I don't know, not as long and if you cannot sing, read; that's fine. There is beautiful theology in these prayers, and they are short and very sweet. So read the Paschal hours in the morning and in the evening for the entire week.

All the serving that's done for Vespers, for matins, for liturgy in every Orthodox Church in the world for this week is always in full vestments as if I'm serving at liturgy because of the festivity of the season.

The doors are open. The Royal doors and the deaconal doors are open in every Orthodox Church in the world for the entire week. They are only closed after the ninth hour on Saturday according to some, but Bishop Peter has told me about another rubric which we follow – to close them after the Small Entrance in Vespers.

I make a note about this, because this is always a very sad day for me because the doors have to be closed, not because God's mercy ends for us, but because we, being fallen, being people that are easily distracted, we cannot take so much grace. We are not ready for the grace that God wishes to give to us, so when the doors are closed; This is a profound theological statement. It is not that God's mercy is shut off from us – No, not at all, but we, because we are immature, are not able to hold onto all of God's mercy. So for a time, God's mercy shines exceptionally bright in all of the services and in this week. But if it were like that every week then we would fall away from Him because we do need rigor. We do need fasting. We do need repentance and penitence because of our nature, not because God requires it of us but because without that kind of rigor that we just went through in the fasting of Great Lent we would not be able to become good and know God Who is good.

We have started reading the Gospel of John and the Acts of the Apostles, and they will be read all throughout the Paschal period. And I explained why

we read the Gospel of John for Pascha because, of course, to know the Resurrection, we have to know Jesus Christ and Saint John more than anyone else ever has explained who Jesus Christ is. There are symbols for the evangelists, and he is the eagle because he soars high above on the wings of theology. Truly, his language, from a grammatical standpoint, is the simplest and, yes, from a theological standpoint it is the deepest.

So we read the Gospel of John during the Paschal period because, as I explained, it is the church's strategy or the church's tradition that when we have a feast we explain more about it later. And so this entire Paschal period, Paschal is really being explained to you in all of the services, in all the hymnology and in the Gospel of John.

And then of course we read the Acts of the Apostles. And why would that be? With Pascha, the Church was strengthened. Some people would say that the Church began on Pentecost. I personally don't think that that's true because I believe that Joseph and Abraham and Isaac, all those holy fathers are part of the Church. But the strengthening of the Church, to spread to the entire universe was accomplished on Pentecost, but there would be no Pentecost without the Resurrection. So the beginnings of the Church as a universal entity are really with Pascha when the disciples were gathering together in the upper room praying.

Now for this first 50 days after Pascha they were afraid because they didn't know what was going to happen and as I explained yesterday, the Resurrection comes to us a little bit by little bit, not all in a flash like the Lord resurrected, but a little bit by little bit so the Apostles only with the coming of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost really understood all things and had the power to proclaim the Gospel to all of mankind.

It would be a very good exercise for all of you to read from the Gospel of John and the Book of Acts. If you pick one, do the Gospel of John and read it every day. If you can read a paragraph, if you can read a chapter, if you can read the daily readings, that's fine too. Read the Gospel of John so that you complete it throughout the Paschal period. It is truly a remarkable book, and it's the kind of book that you must read literally a hundred thousand times to fully understand. So every time you read it, something new will come out to you that is important for your salvation. So read the Gospel of John and read the Acts. But if you have to pick one, you only have so much time or so much energy or so much zeal, read the Gospel of John.

The theme during this time is about enlightenment, gradual enlightenment. We see it already with the Gospel here about Thomas<sup>6</sup>. Right now we only hear the first half of the story. The second half will be this coming Sunday, and the first half, as Thomas said, "Unless I see the prints of the nails, the holes in his hand and his side and unless I put my finger in them, I won't believe." And so for eight days, he anguished because his fellow friends, the Apostles, the women that had been around Jesus, they believed, but Thomas didn't. But he was faithful, and his faithfulness would be rewarded. So that on Sunday we will proclaim him as the first to declare unequivocally the two natures of Jesus Christ when he said, "My Lord and my God."

During this entire Paschal period up until Pentecost, we do not say "O Heavenly King. . ." Why would that be? Why would it be that we do not say "O, Heavenly King. . ."? Anybody know? Well, sometimes the Church speaks about something and teaches us and sometimes they do not speak about something and teach us. "O Heavenly King, Comforter. . .", is about the Holy Spirit, and we are asking Him to come and abide in us. Well, what is going to happen in fifty days? The Holy Spirit will come and abide in us, liturgically, at Pentecost, the coming of the Holy Spirit. So the lack of this prayer is reminding us of the greatness of the coming of the Holy Spirit. That's why we omit this prayer, and we substitute instead of it "Christ is risen" three times, and then when we get to Ascension, then we substitute the

Ascension Troparion for those days until Pentecost. So don't say "O Heavenly King. . ."

Oh, by the way, no prostrations either. There are no prostrations (in church, but many will still do them in private) until Pentecost also, and that is to recall the joy of the season.

See, there's a rhyme and a reason to the things the church does. There is a deep theological significance to some of these deeply held traditions. Why we prostrate at certain times and why we don't at others. Why we eat all foods on some occasions and do not eat most foods on others. So we are not prostrating, nor are we saying "O Heavenly King".

There's a few other liturgical things if you really understand the services for instance, I will just say one. In matins we'll always sing, "Having beheld the Resurrection of Christ. . ." three times on the Sunday vigil, whereas normally it's sung once. And there is a bunch of other little differences, but the important ones for you are you don't fast this week, you don't prostrate until Pentecost. You don't say "O Heavenly King. . ." until Pentecost, and you sing "Christ is risen" every day, and you say the Paschal hours and rejoice. As is usual, I have to tell you as a pastor, to warn you, that this is a period of time when the devil who is that roaring lion, is looking about for whom he can devour<sup>7</sup>, and you know he devours a lot of people with summer sausage and with bacon and with butter and all of the delicacies that we have not had before. Don't eat too much of that. Eat them and enjoy them, but don't gorge yourself so that you still can pray.

You don't pray as much, but you should pray consistently the Paschal hours in the morning and in the evening. And rejoice in the Resurrection in that way.

So there is good news that although we need about 20 thousand dollars that we don't have, we have an anonymous donor that has come forward and wishes to sort of get some activity and interest and zeal among our parish family, to raise eight thousand dollars. This donor has pledged eight thousand dollars in matching funds. Okay, the way this works is this. The clergy are not part of the matching funds. So Father Nicholas and I cannot give to this fund in order to have it matched but if you give, you give one hundred dollars, it is matched with one hundred dollars. If you give a thousand it is matched with a thousand dollars, up to eight thousand dollars which means if we are zealous, we would have 16 thousand dollars which is very close to what we need. With some other things coming in, we would probably be able to do it.

So what I would ask you to do is take this letter and give yourself and ask others to give and to designate that it is for the matching funds and we can raise this money then. It's a lot easier to raise eight thousand dollars than it is to raise 16.

May God bless you, and now let's feast, what do you say? I don't think there was any tofu in there at all. Okay. Let's go bless it.

Priest Seraphim Holland 2010.

This homily is at:

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sunday-01\\_2010-04-04+agape-vespers+paschal-instructions.html](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sunday-01_2010-04-04+agape-vespers+paschal-instructions.html)

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sunday-01\\_2010-04-04+agape-vespers+paschal-instructions.doc](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sunday-01_2010-04-04+agape-vespers+paschal-instructions.doc)

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## Bright Thursday. Nicodemus meets Jesus. Illumination by degrees, but only if we stay in the kitchen!

The story of Nicodemus meeting with Christ **is our story**. We are Nicodemus, and Peter, and Mary Magdalene, and Thomas, and the Blind Man, and the Paralytic, and all the rest, whom we have read about or will read about in this season; for them and us, illumination comes over time, and always with great effort and waiting on our part.

There is a constant theme throughout this Paschal period, up to and including Pentecost. It is the sure and certain aspect of everyone's life – we come to an understanding of holy things slowly, and only if we struggle and endure.

We read about these people, such as Nicodemus, and still, we do not really “get it.” He was a flesh and blood person; He did not understand all things, he made mistakes, he sinned, and he was confused. He was just like us, or shall we say, he had our weaknesses. It remains to be seen if we have a share in his strengths.

Look for a Saint in the bible that did not have feet of clay! Peter, David, all the Apostles – anyone! They struggled with their human condition, and it took them time to get better – to understand, to do, to repent, to become what they were made to be. So it is with us.

So many stories, and throughout them all, *a golden thread* – God's grace is sufficient even if it does not seem sufficient, even if we cannot feel it at all, even if our weak-willed humanity gets in our own way as we crawl towards God! If we wait, and act upon what we know, God will help us. It does not matter what we feel – it matters what we do, and that we endure.

Nicodemus is a perfect example of this golden thread. He came to Jesus by night. Why? Because he was a Pharisee, and he was afraid of being found out by his peers! This is not an auspicious beginning for the man we would later call “equal to the Apostles”, because he was the first to evangelize Great Britain.

Nicodemus knew there was something different and profound about this man Jesus because he has heard him speak in a way, unlike any other man, with authority, unlike the Pharisees or Scribes. He was a thoughtful man, good, seeking God, but the ensuing conversation shows he was very confused, and the Lord even rebuked him because of this, saying:

“Art thou a master of Israel, and knowest not these things?”

Jesus told him fantastic things, and Nicodemus must have gone away more confused than when he first came. We know he remained a Pharisee; he did not become a constant follower of Jesus. Perhaps he was still afraid of what would happen to him if he declared his loyalty to Jesus, perhaps he was still very confused about Jesus and his teaching. None of this matters. We know he endured; he wrestled with these things, and he came to know the truth, because after the crucifixion, he became brave, and took the body of Jesus from Pilate, to prepare it for burial, ostensibly ruining his career as a Pharisee, and endangering his life.

It took some time for Nicodemus to understand. As his understanding grew, he found the courage to act upon it, and now we call him “Equal to the Apostles.”

It is like this with everyone, you and me too. We struggle with faith, we wrestle with ourselves. Sometimes it feels like we are losing. We know what we should become and we are not becoming it; we have times of confusion, sorrow, unbelief in various forms. This happens to everyone! Anybody who says they have never had a moment when their faith was weak, or even barely there – is a liar!

Our weakness does not matter. Our confusion does not matter. Not even our sins matter. The only thing that will kill us if we quit. Nicodemus spent three years pondering the things Jesus said to him; he did not quit. As we learn, we must do. When we will learn, and how – these things are not revealed to us, because: “The wind bloweth where it listeth, and thou hearest the sound thereof, but canst not tell whence it cometh, and whither it goeth: so is every one that is born of the Spirit.”

We have been born of water – we have been baptized. We will be born of the Spirit; we must wait, and endure, and act upon the truth as we understand it and develop a greater ability to act on it. If we do this, then truly Nicodemus story, will be our story in every way.

Christ is risen!

<http://www.orthodox.net/scripture/pascha-week-01-thursday.html>

<http://www.orthodox.net/scripture/pascha-week-01-thursday.doc>

## Why are the altar doors open on Pascha? When are they closed and what does it mean?

### 2nd Sunday of Pascha; Thomas Sunday

2011

Christ is risen! Truly He is risen!

As you can see, the doors are now closed. The doors were open for all of Bright Week, from the time of Pascha, all the way until we sang the first Sticheron of Great Vespers for St. Thomas Sunday. It happens to be in the first tone. It's from the Octoechos, so we would sing this every eight weeks.

We sang "When the doors were shut," and then we shut the doors. Father Nicholas and I were a little bit tardy. It actually was on the next one that we shut them, but the meaning is still the same.

"When the doors were shut and the disciples were gathered together, Thou didst suddenly enter in, O our almighty Jesus our God, and standing in their midst and granting them peace Thou didst fill them with the Holy Spirit and didst command them to wait and in no wise to depart from Jerusalem until they were invested with power from on high. Wherefore we cry out to Thee, O our Enlightenment, Resurrection and Peace, glory be to Thee."

There's actually two different usages, the one that I had learned before was to shut the royal doors before Vespers begins on Saturday night. But

Vladyka Peter told me about what they do, and I find it to be very meaningful, that when we say "when the doors were shut," then we shut them at Vespers. And since Vespers is a transition from the previous day to the next, it's appropriate at that time.

Now what does it mean for the doors to be shut? Well, what does it mean for them to be open? Normally they're shut. Why were they open for Pascha? They are open because it is a sign of God's grace overflowing and filling us. All things are made new on Pascha, and God's grace is apparent to all.

Now, there's an unfortunate fact of our human nature, and that is, if we are not careful, if we stop struggle for a period of time, we become lazy and we become forgetful and we can fall into despondency and all manner of sins. It's not because God will not help us if we do not struggle. It is because our nature is such that we need to struggle. It's just human nature. When you stop the struggle, you go backwards, not forwards.

So the doors are open for all of Pascha. We don't fast for all of the Paschal Bright Week. And then the doors are closed. And we return to normal fasting as of tomorrow or the next day, really, Monday, because then we will have normal fasting rules from then on. So Wednesdays and Fridays we won't eat meat and cheese and eggs, except we will be able to have wine and oil throughout all of Pascha. This still shows something of the Paschal joy.

All of these things are not just minutia of rules, but they are all things that should remind us about ourselves and about God. When the doors are open, we feel the Paschal joy. When they are closed, we realize this is because of us, because we get lazy and because without struggle we will fall away from God.

And also it means another thing, another tragic thing. But this tragedy can be rectified. It is rectified by the Resurrection of the God-Man Jesus Christ. And that tragedy is that we cannot receive all of the Grace of God that He wishes to give us. We're too weak for it. It is as if we have weak eyes and

we go out into the sun, and we must close our eyes or shield them because it is too bright. The Grace of God is too bright and too holy for us because we are not holy. But over time we become capable of having all of the Grace of God that He wishes to give us and containing it in ourselves.

But now we are not ready. So the doors are closed. It's always kind of a sad time for me but a very instructive time. I'm not ready for all of the Grace of God that He wants to give me. Neither are you. But we will become ready if we struggle, if we pray to God, if we fast at the appointed times and pray at the appointed times. Not because there are ten rules that we need to follow or ten thousand, but because of our desire for knowing God. Then, yes, we will become perfect, and the doors will always be open in the Kingdom.

May God bless you and help you. The blessing of the Lord be upon you through His grace and love for mankind always now and ever and unto the ages of ages. Amen.

Priest Seraphim Holland 2011

Transcribed by the hand of Helen; May God save her and her loved ones.

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## St Thomas Sunday. "My Lord and My God"

In the Name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen. Christ is risen!

Today is the second Sunday of Pascha already. It is the Sunday of St. Thomas. Today we read about, as the church calls it, St. Thomas's "believing unbelief."<sup>8</sup>

There is a theme here that the church will be talking about now in the light of the Resurrection during the whole Pentecostarion period: the enlightenment of man. The Resurrection is being applied now. We see it in the Acts that we're reading for quite some time currently. In the light of the Resurrection, we see what's happening. We see how many people were healed, how many people were converted, and how lives were changed. Even the shadow of the apostles healed people of their infirmities.<sup>9</sup> In the light of the Resurrection, there was activity, there was motion, and there was enlightenment.

St Thomas, who was no different than you or I; he had to be enlightened also. Everyone has different levels of understanding on various things, even among the apostles, even among the saints. It is fascinating to look and see how our Lord, in the forty days that He spent on the earth, enlightened so many using different ways to enlighten them, and also throughout the whole of the gospels how He reached people where they needed to be reached. The final destination is always the same: to follow the commandments and to become purified, so that we can know Christ in an intimate way. But sometimes Christ teaches certain people a little bit differently. In fact, everyone is treated a little bit differently.

Thomas wasn't there the first night of Pascha.<sup>10</sup> He had left probably on some errand, and that is when Christ came, the doors being shut. And Jesus spoke to the eleven, or actually, ten<sup>11</sup> at that point, and they were glad. I have always marveled how in the scriptures great, momentous occasions are stated so laconically. "Then were the disciples glad when they saw the Lord."<sup>12</sup> Indeed, they were glad, when they saw the God-man! But Thomas was not there, and the Resurrection was such an incredible thing; he cannot really be faulted for not believing.

Peter didn't believe when he saw the grave clothes, only John did, when they went into the grave and saw the clothes lying folded up.<sup>13</sup> John saw and believed, but Peter didn't. He went away, wondering in himself what had come to pass.<sup>14</sup>

Mary Magdalene, who saw the stone rolled away from the tomb together with the Theotokos, didn't immediately believe in the Resurrection. She came back to the tomb with myrrh and aloes to anoint the Lord, He Who in her mind was dead. She was weeping because He wasn't in the tomb.<sup>15</sup> She was weeping for someone Who was dead. That's why we sing, "Do not weep for one who is dead," it says (in a paraphrase). "He is not dead, He is not here, He is alive and risen." In our exapostilarion we speak of how Mary misunderstood. And our Lord came to her, and she thought He was the gardener, till He spoke to her and just in the hearing of His voice, when He said, "Mary", and then she recognized Him.<sup>16</sup>

Other disciples spent an entire day's journey with Christ, and didn't understand. They were Luke and Cleopas, on the way to Emmaus.<sup>17</sup> The tomb had already been empty for some time, and they were walking a long distance. It says in the scriptures 60 furlongs, quite a long distance, a day's journey, in the hot sun, and our Lord drew alongside them, and He spoke to them, and they didn't understand Who He was. They thought that He was a misinformed stranger because He made like He wondered what the events were in the past couple of days.

But their hearts burned within them. Something about this Man captivated them, when He spoke to them about the scriptures, and opened their understanding. That's why it says: "And then opened He their understanding of the scriptures." And when they sat down, and when He broke bread, (which was, of course, the Body and Blood of Christ), then they saw Him, and He vanished. And as they were making their way back in the wee hours of the morning, another day's journey (they took two days journeys in one day), Christ appeared to the other apostles, save Thomas.

You see how He enlightened people where they needed to be enlightened.

Luke and Cleopas must have needed this conversation with the Lord, and to see Him in the breaking of the bread, to have the point brought home that yes, the Lord had risen.

Mary had to be spoken with by Lord. She had to see Him.

John believed just by seeing the empty tomb.

Peter was met by the Lord, the church understands.<sup>18</sup> Peter was met individually by the Lord, because after all, he was a bit shaken, wasn't he? Peter was a man of great bravery. He can't be faulted for his denying Christ three times. We would have done it a thousand times. But he was much shaken because of this. Because of the emotional turmoil he was in, it was very difficult for him to believe in the Resurrection, because he was all wrapped up with his feeling so completely unworthy of what the Lord had called him to do. So the Lord had to meet with Peter individually, apart from the other apostles. And in fact, Peter was the first of the apostles to see the risen Lord. And I suppose maybe the second to believe after John, who without seeing believed.

And now the last to find out, after eight long days of hearing from the apostles about the Lord being risen, Thomas, is in the room and the Lord comes, through the doors again, which were shut, passing through the doors, because after all, His body is a human body, but it is a transfigured human body. It's not subject to the same kind of laws that we are subject to. It doesn't get tired; it doesn't get sick. And that's the way we will be as well. The way Christ was in His transfigured body is a prophecy for us of how our bodies will be as well.

Jesus comes in and speaks very gently to Thomas. He says, "I know what you need. You need to touch Me. Feel the prints of the nails in my hands. Feel the slit in my side, and be not faithless, but believing."<sup>19</sup> And then Thomas has the privilege of being the first of the apostles to proclaim unambiguously, in clear terms, the dual nature of Christ's humanity and His divinity. It is the first confession of faith in the scriptures, where Christ is proclaimed God and man openly. He says, "My Lord and my God!"<sup>20</sup>

Thomas had to wait a while, but God gave him that great privilege of almost, shall we say, beginning the symbol of faith<sup>21</sup>. What a great privilege it was.

In the coming week we will be speaking about the myrrh-bearing women<sup>22</sup>, and there is a theme throughout the story of the myrrh-bearing women of their continuing enlightenment, just like for Thomas or for Peter or for Luke and Cleopas or for the other apostles. And then we go onto the blind man and the lame man, the paralytic. We see how the Resurrection is applied.

Why does the church do this? Why do we speak of things that have to do with enlightenment and healing right after Pascha? It is because the Resurrection applies to us in our life now. It's essential to understand this. That's why I have been speaking of it so often. It's essential to understand, because you must know that God has given you the ability to be able to get rid of your sins, your

passions, the problems in your life, that are making you be away from God. You have the ability, through the Resurrection. And all these examples of people that partially believed, even the great apostles, who were at times disbelievers, at times were cowards, at times were at odds with each other and vied amongst themselves who would be greatest, and all the other things -- even them -- the Lord purified them, and brought them to a great wholeness.

If He can do it with them and do it with all the other examples in the scriptures, with the paralytic and the blind man and the woman at the well, named Photini<sup>23</sup>, and all the others, then He can do it with us.

I tell you, the Resurrection is not something that you believe in as an event that occurred in the past. Nor is it something that you believe, and say that it will happen in the future, like Mary and Martha did, saying, "Oh Lord, I believe in the Resurrection. In the last day, all will be resurrected."<sup>24</sup> When their brother Lazarus lay dead, and Christ showed them, "I am the Resurrection. If I live in you, then you are resurrected now, not later." It is essential to understand this.

A Christian who understands that Christ's becoming man makes him able to do holy things will not fall prey to despondency. Despondency is the negation of belief in God. Despondency is a type of atheism. You should fear despondency and confess it every time. It is a terrible sin because in it, you are rejecting the Resurrection. God can save you, and God will save you if you live the Christian life. Yes, indeed, you must consider yourself unworthy of salvation, but you must also know that Christ has promised it.

So live as a Christian, fast as a Christian, think as a Christian, and when you cannot do things properly, when you do things that are sinful, run to confession with the sure hope and sure knowledge, that God will receive your repentance, because of the Resurrection. I tell you, if you live in the light of the Resurrection, you will not become despondent.

As a pastor, I believe that the number one sin I see is despondency. Sometimes it is cloaked, so that people can have a sin and may be despondent about it, but not so noticeably despondent, so that it is a sort of semi-excuse. And sometimes it is because people really desire to change, and they just can't believe that they can really change. Mary and Martha couldn't believe that their brother would be resurrected after four days. The apostles, many of them, could not believe that our Lord, Who spoke of the Resurrection over and over and over again, could be resurrected. It took many proofs for some of them, such as Thomas, and the other ones as well.



You know, it says "Many things the Lord did, many signs He did, but not everything is written in this book."<sup>25</sup>

By the way, as an aside, you realize that the Lord taught the apostles so much that is not written down, that is part of our holy tradition now. The apostles transmitted it to their disciples, and so on. It wasn't written down, but it was precious, and St. John only in a dark way refers to it.

So today, we see an example of a man, Thomas, enlightened. Christ went out of His way to enlighten him. He sort of accorded him special treatment, as it were. And Thomas believed, and he confessed. Christ did and does the same thing for us, to bring us to enlightenment. And now we must believe and confess.

Now He said something else that's very important, important not to pass over. He said it before Thomas was there, and many other times when Thomas heard. He said, "As the Father hath sent me, so send I you."<sup>26</sup>

And by extension, it is the same for us. No, we don't have the role of the apostles. We are not bishops, and we don't have the grace that has been bestowed upon the apostles, but we are sent along basically the same path: the path of obedience to the same Gospel, the path of obedience to the commandments of our God, the life in the church, and everything that living as an Orthodox Christian entails.

Later on, just after this reading, the disciples, seven of them, are fishing, and the Lord tells them to let down their nets, and they had a catch, and then Peter is told to bring the catch to the shore, a hundred and fifty and three fishes, and yet the net did not break.<sup>27</sup> And later, after they ate, our Lord restored Peter by asking him three times, "Simon, son of Jonah, lovest thou me?" and then He showed him how he would die.<sup>28</sup> This is tied in with when He was saying, "As my Father hath sent Me, so send I you."

We must use Christ as the example of how to live, whether as an apostle or anyone else. The Christian life is one of difficulty and one of strife. We are in the light of the Resurrection, but we can never get far away from knowing that our life is a difficult one. We make it so because of our sins, sometimes, and other times because of the evil of the world surrounding us. Follow the example of the saints. Follow the example of the apostles. Live as they lived, which means you live the life in the church.

And brothers and sisters, always believe that the Resurrection applies to you, now. Fear disbelief in it. Every time you fall into despondency, berate

yourself for being a fool and gazing into an empty tomb, and wondering where the Lord is. Don't be like this. Believe in the Resurrection, and believe that you can be changed, and through struggle, arduous struggle, through many tears, through ups and downs, and even in the midst of your sins, God will perfect you, but you must believe. Amen.

The Gospel for St. Thomas Sunday John 20:19-31

Then the same day at evening, being the first day of the week, when the doors were shut where the disciples were assembled for fear of the Jews, came Jesus and stood in the midst, and saith unto them, Peace be unto you. {20} And when he had so said, he showed unto them his hands and his side. Then were the disciples glad, when they saw the Lord. {21} Then said Jesus to them again, Peace be unto you: as my Father hath sent me, even so send I you. {22} And when he had said this, he breathed on them, and saith unto them, Receive ye the Holy Ghost: {23} Whose soever sins ye remit, they are remitted unto them; and whose soever sins ye retain, they are retained. {24} But Thomas, one of the twelve, called Didymus, was not with them when Jesus came. {25} The other disciples therefore said unto him, We have seen the Lord. But he said unto them, Except I shall see in his hands the print of the nails, and put my finger into the print of the nails, and thrust my hand into his side, I will not believe. {26} And after eight days again his disciples were within, and Thomas with them: then came Jesus, the doors being shut, and stood in the midst, and said, Peace be unto you. {27} Then saith he to Thomas, Reach hither thy finger, and behold my hands; and reach hither thy hand, and thrust it into my side: and be not faithless, but believing. {28} And Thomas answered and said unto him, My Lord and my God. {29} Jesus saith unto him, Thomas, because thou hast seen me, thou hast believed: blessed are they that have not seen, and yet have believed. {30} And many other signs truly did Jesus in the presence of his disciples, which are not written in this book: {31} But these are written, that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God; and that believing ye might have life through his name.

Priest Seraphim Holland 2009

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## "Having become bold" What made Joseph, Nicodemus and the Myrrh-Bearers bold?

*Myrrh-Bearing Women Mark 15:43-16:8 2012*

In the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit, Amen. Christ is risen! Truly He is risen! Hristos voskrese! Voistinu voskrese!

I want to tell you, before I begin, about some people that I want you to remember during the Liturgy. There is an especially important time, right after the Epiklesis, the calling down of the Holy Spirit<sup>29</sup>, when we are to pray for those we especially care for or that have special needs. We also of course sometimes commemorate people that have special needs in the Great Entrance -- which will be coming up soon -- and also of course we have the custom of praying from a list, of people for their general needs, travelers and among the sick.

Now, I want you to do this after the Epiklesis; I want you to remember the sick, because this is a sacred responsibility of everyone. It is not only the responsibility of the clergy, absolutely not! Everyone should pour their heart out to God during the Divine Liturgy. And this time after the Epiklesis, is the time especially to pray with your heart for God.

[Several people and their needs were mentioned] Try to remember those names, and as a sacred trust during the Epiklesis pray for those people. It's

very, very important. **We are not passive in Liturgy.** It's part of the reason why we stand and part of the reason why pews are such a terrible thing: Because they encourage passivity. You are participants in the Liturgy. The Liturgy means "the work of the people". It's not the work of Father Nicholas and myself. It's the work of the people. So pray for those people, okay? And you will hear them in the entrance and also hear them in the list of people that we pray for in the fervent Ektenia.



Among the most important words in today's Gospel that are truly amazing, that are too big to talk about or understand, are when it says that **Joseph become bold**. Remember, our Lord had just been crucified. The Jews were looking to kill everybody that was associated with Him. People were in terror. Everybody had run away. But Joseph became bold. This is a marvelous thing. It was dangerous to go and ask for the body of Jesus, who was a known felon, a criminal, a heretic. Boldness doesn't care about danger.

Do you know what boldness cares about? It is only one thing. **True Christian boldness is based on one virtue. Love.** Where there is love there is not fear. Now, I don't mean that you won't have emotional fear, but you won't be paralyzed with your fear.

Joseph was frightened when he did this, but he knew he had to do it. His heart told him he had to do it, and so he became bold and did it, and he went in to crave the body of Jesus and got it, and Nicodemus helped; St. John adds that detail. And they worked very quickly to be able to put Him in the grave to still abide by the Jewish Sabbath, which was fast approaching.

This kind of boldness is what you and I need, brothers and sisters. It's the same boldness that the Myrrh-Bearing Women had because they also were doing something perilous, and not only this; they didn't even have any idea how they were going to accomplish it. There was a gigantic stone that had to be rolled with many men using a fulcrum to be able to get it in front of the tomb, and now the tomb was guarded by the best of the best, the centurions, hard men who wouldn't hesitate to kill someone. They weren't going to help roll away the stone.

They had no idea how they were going to accomplish their task, but they were bold. They had been frightened before, but then they were bold. Where there is the love of God, **perfect love casteth out fear**. We have to aim to have this kind of love, brothers and sisters, and this kind of boldness.

We are now in an era where there are a lot of micro persecutions. There will be major ones soon enough. But there are micro persecutions now. Perhaps your management is coercing you to give to the United Way. The United Way gives to a lot of things that are entirely un-Christian. You hear people talk about different kinds of immorality, and perhaps you feel afraid to say what you really feel.

I have noticed that there are Christians now, Orthodox Christians that are changing their opinions about things that God has always spoken of because they're afraid. They see that most other people don't have this opinion; it seems like most of the world doesn't have this opinion.

You must beg the Lord to help you be bold. But this **boldness comes from love**, an all-consuming love for the Lord. We must have this boldness.

Now, an interesting thing, a very important thing about the boldness of Joseph and Nicodemus and the Myrrh-Bearing Women, is that what they were doing was because of a misunderstanding. Our Lord said He would rise again. He had made it very clear. In retrospect, they understood that it was clear. So what need would they have to anoint the body? None. Our hymns even say that: "Why do you seek for the living among the dead?". He is alive. But they thought He was dead. But their love for Him made them bold even though only shortly before they had been terrified, and they didn't get it right. The Myrrh-Bearers were going on an errand for someone Who was not there. But they didn't know that. And so with what they knew, with their feeble understanding, they acted out of love.

**And if you act out of love, God will always make a good come out of it. Always, without fail.** You might not see the good. There might be bad things that happen to you. But always, always, God's Word will not fail to return to Him. And the love that we give to God will always be good, and always cause our Lord to work in some merciful and unseen way that will be for our salvation and the salvation of others: Every time, without exception.

So the fact that the Myrrh-Bearers were doing something that showed that they did not understand what the Lord had been talking about for the past three years, is not important. And you must apply this to your life. I have learned now, being a priest for so many years, there's so much ignorance. Often I feel like I don't know anything, and yet I do. Based upon whatever

knowledge I have and the small amount of love that I have for God, I do. And then I see things happen that are completely unrelated to what I thought was going to happen.

It should be that way with you, too. Ignorance is no excuse. You still have to act on what you know with boldness. Don't be afraid. Act on what you know because of love for God. You will have many opportunities, today, tomorrow, the rest of your life, always to act with boldness and love for God. And your ignorance God will enlighten. But only those who love God will He enlighten. So we must follow the example of these Myrrh-Bearers and of Joseph and Nicodemus and be bold.

Now, boldness comes out of a deep longing to be with God, a deep love for Him. You don't have to be smart. You don't have to be theologically astute, but you do have to **desire to know the things of God**. I would say it's not possible to be bold if we don't cultivate our love for God through our prayer, through fasting, through reading of holy things, through the Services. Otherwise, our hearts are cold. We might know a few things. But we will be making compromises in our lives and we won't even realize that. Or when we do realize, then we will have dug ourselves a hole; we will be afraid to speak the truth at that point.

Cultivate your love for God, and realize that you are a soldier; you're called to service. The Scripture says the Kingdom of Heaven is being won by violence. That violence is our boldness to do what is right because of love for God, no matter what the consequences.

So let us follow the example of these Myrrh-Bearers, and Joseph and Nicodemus who acted in boldness. That boldness was given to them by God. They didn't possess it on their own. It was given to them because of their love for Him, not because of their knowledge because they were wrong; they were administering to a dead man, and He wasn't dead.

Let us be like these holy saints. Cultivate your love for God, brothers, and sisters, and look **for opportunities** to be bold. And when you're not bold, when you're afraid to make the Sign of the Cross in front of a bunch of people you don't know or your family or at your business meeting, or when you're afraid to speak out when people are saying things that are wrong, or when you do not feel moral authority because of your own sins, force yourself to be bold. This latter obstacle is probably the major source where we are not bold, where we need to correct someone whom we love, but we look at ourselves and we think I'm such a terrible person, I have no right at all, no strength to be able to talk to this person. That's not humility acting.



That's cowardice. You have no right to not do something good because you think you are bad!

If you have boldness before God, it is because of love for God, and even in the midst of knowing your sins, God will tell you, call your name; and you must be like Samuel and say, "Here am I." Then, no matter what it is, do it. There are many things all of us need to do. But it starts with loving God, and the love for God will wash away our ignorance and our timidity. May God grant it. Amen.

Transcribed by Helen, May the Lord save her and her loved ones.  
Priest Seraphim Holland 2012

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## The way to Emmaus is the path of the Christian Life.

Luke 24:12-25 #113. Matinal Gospel 5

Note: There are 11 Sunday Matins Gospels. They are all about the resurrection. They are each read in their turn Sunday morning at matins. Once we finish with the 11<sup>th</sup> gospel we return to reading the first the next week. However during the festal time after Pascha until the Ascension, we cram all 11 Gospels into our readings. Some of them are read on Sunday, and some of them are read at other times during the week.

I want to tell you something about this Gospel. This matinal Gospel is not only a recounting of sacred history; it is also a type or a template for the Christian life. It is an example of how we should live and what we should expect! For spiritual edification, we can look at this story in an allegorical way and glean many benefits from it.

This story shows very clearly the path of the Christian life. The two apostles of the 70, on the way to Emmaus, were very disheartened; they were frightened, they were beaten down, but they were not without faith. They did not understand (they did not yet believe that Christ was risen), but in some way they still had faith and the desire to know our Savior and serve Him.

Our Lord meets them on the way. Imagine this picture! Two disheartened, frightened men are walking in the heat of the day, to a city that is a full day's journey away, no knowing really what tomorrow would bring, but certainly suspecting that it would bring the point of a sword. Our Lord comes to them and speaks to them on the way, and they don't see Him and don't know Him. Their eyes were holden that they could not see Him.

This is the way that it is for us so many times, brothers and sisters. We walk, on a long journey on the way, and many times we do not see. We only know by faith, we only know by our sure convictions, and something that is in our heart that warms us, and we know that we are following the true path. And, even if we cannot conquer a sin, or don't know the purpose of this or that, or the reason why something is happening to us or to a loved one, we still walk on the way.

This is the way that Christ walks. We must walk with Christ! We must be in the way in which He walks, just like the apostles, just like the blind men<sup>30</sup>. This is a long way, and the day is indeed far spent before God fully reveals Himself to us. This will be at the end of the age, but a foretaste of this revealing, a true "piece" of it, as it were, is in the breaking of bread. Our Lord enlightened His two disciples in the breaking of bread, and they saw Who He was. To this day, he is revealed to us in the breaking of bread, that is the Eucharist, but we realize this distinctly only after we have walked many miles with Him, with faith.

What happened? The day was far spent, the sun was setting, and they were tired. It would be a long and dangerous trip back, and there are robbers on the road, and what did they do? They made haste to go back, taking hours and hours, arriving in the wee hours of the morning, way past midnight, and the other apostles were up, who said He has appeared unto Simon; He is risen. And they corroborated this with their own testimony.

The two disciples were Luke, who wrote this gospel, and Cleophas, who was the brother of St. Joseph the Betrothed. He wrote with conviction, just like St. John wrote, who said "what I say is true."<sup>31</sup> He wrote this way because he saw, and he believed, and he experienced and he believed. This seeing and experiencing can only be accomplished when we may a great effort to walk in the heat of the day, struggling against our hot passions.

This gospel is a deep mine. We can extract many golden nuggets from it, and they will make us rich, because they will show us how to live. Even in the midst of what is wrong with us, it shows us how to live. It shows us what will happen if we follow on that road and on that journey. It contains historical fact, but more importantly, it contains spiritual fact. It is what God will do to a man. He will enlighten him, and make him able to see, over the course of time. God help us to be on this road until the end of our life, so that we would see, in the end completely and clearly, not in a glass darkly, but face to face, crying "Abba, Father", and being called "friend". God bless you.

[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/matins-gospel-05\\_2002-06-03+the-road-to-emmaus.doc](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/matins-gospel-05_2002-06-03+the-road-to-emmaus.doc)  
[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/matins-gospel-05\\_2002-06-03+the-road-to-emmaus.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/matins-gospel-05_2002-06-03+the-road-to-emmaus.mp3)



## Questions about Bright week -Answers

**ANSWER 1** Bright week begins with the Sunday of Pascha, and comes to a close on Bright Saturday, at Vespers. One may actually argue that Bright week comes to a close before the ninth hour (which precedes Vespers), since the royal doors and deacons doors, which have been wide open all week, are closed. This is a sad and significant moment. Just like our forefathers Adam and Eve, we cannot remain in paradise in this life, because

of our sins. Ours is a life of struggle against our passions, which hold us back from full realization of paradise in this life.

**ANSWER 2** According to the sun's rising and setting, Bright week is seven days, (Sunday through Saturday) but to the church, liturgically, it is one day - the "eighth day".

**ANSWER 3** The fasting typicon for Bright week is easy to remember - do not fast! Of course, all bishops and other monastics keep their abstinence

from meat, but they are profoundly experienced at filling this "gap" with delicious cheeses and fish. All foods are permitted until the second Wednesday after Pascha, which is a regular fast day, with wine and olive oil allowed.

**ANSWER 4** Since the entire week of Pascha, otherwise known as Bright week, is the "eighth day", and according to the Lord, "in the Resurrection they neither marry, nor are given in marriage, but are as the angels of God in heaven" (Matthew 22:30), it is a pious tradition that those who are married "be as the angels". This is abstinence not because of fasting, as marital abstinence otherwise is, but because of the joy of the Resurrection. Not everyone can bear this, and the marriage bed is undefiled in any case, but for those who can observe this custom, there is profound meaning.

**ANSWER 5** The Feast of the Life Giving Spring is celebrated Bright Friday. This icon may be seen on-line at (<http://www.skete.com/fx020004.htm>). Here is an excellent explanation of this feast, from the EXCELLENT St. John the Baptist Web Page (<http://www.stjohndc.org/icons/i9604.htm>)

This icon has a wonderful and comforting appearance. Depicted is an enormous stone chalice, standing in a wide reservoir, filled with water. Above the chalice, holding in Her arms the Preeternal Infant and wearing a crown, hovers the Most Holy Virgin.

To the reservoir filled with life-giving water have streamed those who thirst. The unfortunate and life-weary drink of the water and become strong and invigorated.

What a wonderful sign ...

It was the 5th century. At that time, in Constantinople, near the so-called "Golden Gates," there was a grove filled with cypress and plane trees, long since dedicated to the Most Holy Theotokos. Within the grove there was a spring, likewise long renowned as a source of miracles. Gradually, the site became overgrown with shrubbery, and the water receded into the mud. Only from the dampness of the earth could one deduce the existence of the spring.

Once upon a time, the warrior Leo Marcellus passed the site, where he met a helpless traveler, a blind man who had lost his way and could not find his way out.

Leo helped him get out onto the path, and led the man, weakened by exhaustion, into the shade to rest, while he himself went off in search of water to refresh the blind one. Then he suddenly heard a voice say: "Leo, do not search far off for water. It is close by." Leo, amazed by the mysterious voice, began to look around, but could find no water. As he stood, sad and pensive, the same voice again addressed him: "King Leo! Go into the shade of the grove, draw of the water which you will find there, and give it to the one who thirsts. Place the mud which you find in the spring upon his eyes. Then you will learn who I am, who it is that for so long has blessed this site. Soon I will help you to erect here a church bearing My name, and all who come here and with faith call upon My name will have their prayers answered, and will be completely healed of their sicknesses.

As soon as Leo, hurriedly reaching the appointed place, had taken mud from the spring and placed it on the eyes of the blind man and had given



him some of the water to drink, the blind man immediately regained his sight. Without a guide, he went into Constantinople, glorifying the grace of the Theotokos.

This occurred during the reign of Emperor Marcian (391-457).

Emperor Marcian was succeeded by Leo Marcellus (457-473). He remembered the appearance of the Theotokos, and ordered that the spring be cleaned of the ooze; earthworks were built to isolate the stream of that spring from other nearby springs, and the water was confined in a large circular stone pool, above which was built a church dedicated to the Theotokos. Emperor Leo called this spring the "Life-giving Spring", for there was revealed the miraculous grace of the Theotokos.

One hundred years after Marcian, reigned the emperor Justinian the Great (527-565), a man greatly devoted to the Orthodox faith. For a long time he suffered from edema, finding no help from doctors, and already considering himself condemned to death. One midnight he heard a voice saying: "You, O king, cannot return to health unless you drink from My spring." The king did not know of which spring the voice spoke, and he fell into despair. Then, during the day, the Theotokos appeared to him, and said: "Arise, O king, go to My spring, and drink of it, and you will be healthy, as you were before." The sick man acted according to the Lady's will. He found the spring, drank of its water, and soon regained his health. Near the church built by Leo, the grateful emperor erected a new magnificent church, where later was founded a populous monastery.

In the 15th Century, the Imperial City fell into the hands of the Muslims. The famous Church of the Life-giving Spring was destroyed, and its building materials were used to construct the mosque of Sultan Bayazet. The church site was covered with earth and crushed stone, so that the very foundations of the church disappeared from sight. The beautiful surrounding areas were turned into a Muslim cemetery. A Turkish sentinel, placed at the ruins of the church, forbade Christians not only to gather at the site, but even to approach there.

Little by little, the strictness of this ban eased, and Christians were permitted to build a small church there. However, in 1821, it was destroyed as well, and the spring itself was filled in. Once again Christians cleaned up the ruins, reopened the spring, and once again drew water from it. Even upon these shards of the former magnificent holy structure, the Theotokos, as before, granted hearings through Her grace. Later, among the broken pieces in one of the windows was found, already half-rotted away through time and dampness, a panel on which were recorded 10 miracles which occurred at the Life-giving Spring during the period 1824-1829.

During the reign of Sultan Mahmoud, the Orthodox received a measure of freedom to conduct religious services. They used it to erect, for the third time, a church above the Life-giving Spring. In 1835, with great pomp, the Ecumenical Patriarch Constantine, celebrating with 20 bishops and an enormous flood of the faithful, consecrated the church which stands to this day. Nearby was built a hospital and alms-house. Even the Muslims spoke with great respect of the Life-giving Spring, and of the Theotokos, Who through it pours out Her grace-filled power. "Great among women Holy Mary" is how they refer to the Most Holy Virgin. The water from the Life-giving Spring they call the "water of Holy Mary."

It is impossible to recount all of the miracles flowing from the Life-giving Spring and bringing grace to kings, to patriarchs, to noted as well as ordinary people. The power of grace acts to this day through the water of the spring. That power is personally experienced not only by Orthodox, but by Catholics, Armenians, and even by the Turks.

**ANSWER 6** The Paschal Hours are appointed for morning and evening prayers, and all the simple daily services, such as the hours, small Compline, and the Midnight Office. These prayers are usually in an Orthodox prayer

book, such as the "Jordanville" prayer book, or the "Old Rite" prayer book, and are very short. The entire service is meant to be sung, and takes less than five minutes. It is also an excellent idea to chant the Paschal canon daily.

**ANSWER 7** The prayer to the Holy Spirit, "O Heavenly King", said in almost every Orthodox prayer service is NOT said from Paschal matins (the first service of the Pentecostarion), which begins at midnight on the Sunday of Pascha, until the Vespers service for Pentecost. Anywhere this prayer occurs it is omitted, and until Ascension Thursday, is substituted with the Paschal troparion (Christ is risen from the dead, trampling down death by death, and upon those in the tombs bestowing life), sung three times. We are like the Apostles during this period, "waiting" for the Holy Spirit to come, and the absence of this prayer makes a strong statement of our profound need for the Holy Spirit.

**ANSWER 8.** The Pentecostarion is used from the first service of Pascha (the Paschal matins) through the Sunday of All Saints, following Pentecost.

**ANSWER 9** It is very easy to feast with foods, and let down spiritually, and forget the inner feast of Pascha. Too much rich food makes it impossible to pray. It also can incite other serious passions, such as lust, anger and despondency. Sometimes people hardly pray during this week, because of overeating, and tiredness. The mind of the church, in her ascetical tradition, has always known this. The church lessens the prayer rule during Bright week so that it is easy to pray, but only if we continue to make an effort, and do not over abuse our freedom to eat delicious foods. We emulated the Apostles and the Myrrh-bearing women by proclaiming "Christ is risen" multiple times during the Paschal vigil; likewise, let us emulate them in joyful, although abbreviated prayer during the period of Bright week.

**ANSWER 10** Paschal vespers (and matins) differ from the regular services in that the priest is always fully vested in all his sacerdotal vestments.

All of bright week, the Psalter is not used, since there is no reading in the church, except for the thanksgiving prayers after communion. (The Psalter is divided into twenty roughly equal sections, called kathismas. Most of the time, during vespers, one full kathisma is chanted, or some would say, "read". Also, most of the time, two kathismas are read during matins) At the vespers "Lord I have cried", the first two verses of the psalm are sung, and the rest of the psalm is skipped until the stichera (hymns) are supposed to begin. It is unfortunate that too many Orthodox churches, because of reckless abandonment of the Holy services and traditions, ALWAYS omit this psalm, and sometimes the kathisma reading as well, and the important symbolism of Bright week is lost to them. The Psalter is considered to be a "penitential" book, and this is the primary reason it is omitted, since we are in the eighth day of the Resurrection all of bright week.

The beginning of vespers is very different during Bright week. After the blessing, "Christ is risen" is sung three times, then the moving and triumphant verses of "Let God arise", interspersed with the Paschal troparion. The priest holds the trikiri (a three branched candlestick, used by a priest only during Pascha, but by a bishop, along with the "dikiri", a two branched candle stick, whenever he serves the Divine Liturgy and certain other services). He also holds the censer, and at each verse of "Let God arise", he censers the four corners of the altar. This is a moving and triumphant moment, much like the singing of "For God is with us" at the Great Compline service. Here is the text:

Christ is risen from the dead, Trampling down death by death, And upon those in the tombs bestowing life. (sung 3 times by the priest, then repeated 3 times by the faithful)

Priest: Let God arise, let His enemies be scattered., and let them that hate Him flee from before His face.

Faithful: Christ is risen from the dead.... (1x)

Priest: As smoke vanishes so let them vanish, as wax melts before the fire.

Faithful: Christ is risen from the dead.... (1x)

Priest: So the sinners will perish before the face of God. But let the righteous be glad.

Faithful: Christ is risen from the dead.... (1x)

Priest: This is the day which the Lord has made. Let us rejoice and be glad in it

Faithful: Christ is risen from the dead.... (1x)

Priest: Glory to the Father, and to the Son, and to the Holy Spirit

Faithful: Christ is risen from the dead.... (1x)

Priest: now and ever, and unto ages of ages. Amen.

Faithful: Christ is risen from the dead.... (1x)

Priest Christ is risen from the dead, Trampling down death by death ...

Faithful: and upon those in the tombs, bestowing life.

Normally, a given week is governed by one "tone". During Bright week, however, since Pascha is the "feast of feasts", a different tone is used each day, starting with the 2nd tone for Sunday vespers, with the seventh tone being skipped.

The Great Prokeimenon is used (a different one each time) instead of the usual Prokeimenon used for each day at vespers.

The paschal vespers for bright Monday includes a gospel reading, which is read in many different languages. This reading is the first half of the story of the doubting of the Holy Apostle Thomas, and this reading is reiterated and completed on the following Sunday of St. Thomas.

<sup>1</sup> [The Mystery before time began explained, and how man can become a god explained - in one hymn. \(mp3 format\)](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/theotokos_2017+mystery-hidden-from-before-time-began_doxasticon.mp3)  
[http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/theotokos\\_2017+mystery-hidden-from-before-time-began\\_doxasticon.mp3](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/theotokos_2017+mystery-hidden-from-before-time-began_doxasticon.mp3)

SYNOPSIS: Exegesis of a Doxastikon (theological hymn of praise about the Theotokos and the incarnation) for the feast of the Annunciation, which was sung on the Eve of the Saturday of Lazarus. This hymn links the two feasts, and all the great feasts. It is the "mystery hidden from before time began", and explain exactly what the incarnation accomplished. We never think of the Theotokos without the incarnation, and what the incarnation consisted of and what it accomplished - sinful man can become a god! We explain this audacious, but scriptural transformation - from a deceived man, a failure, to a god. This hymn is one of the best examples, but still only one of hundreds which explain the incarnation and salvation to the faithful who read the services and are zealous to hear the hymns, interrupting their daily routines in order to hear about the bread from heaven. 2017-04-07

<sup>2</sup> Psalm 81:6 (Sept) I said: Ye are gods, and all of you the sons of the Most High.  
John 10:34 KJV Jesus answered them, Is it not written in your law, I said, Ye are gods?

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<sup>3</sup> Genesis 1:26-27 KJV And God said, Let us make man in our image, after our likeness: and let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the fowl of the air, and over the cattle, and over all the earth, and over every creeping thing that creepeth upon the earth. (27) So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him; male and female created he them.

<sup>4</sup> Luke 17:20-21 KJV And when he was demanded of the Pharisees, when the kingdom of God should come, he answered them and said, The kingdom of God cometh not with observation: (21) Neither shall they say, Lo here! or, lo there! for, behold, the kingdom of God is within you.

<sup>5</sup> We have them available on our website in English and Slavonic:

- [PASCHAL Hours - HTML](#)
- [RTF Format, double sided, two per side, for printing as a convenient card](#)
- [PDF Format, double sided, two per side, for printing as a convenient card](#)
- [Pascha hours - Slavonic - html](#)
- [Pascha hours - Slavonic - RTF Format, double sided, two per side, for printing as a convenient card](#)
- [Pascha hours - Slavonic - PDF Format, double sided, two per side, for printing as a convenient card](#)

Go to the page: <http://www.orthodox.net/pascha/> for these prayers and many other things about Pascha.

<sup>6</sup> Homilies here: [http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/index.html#Thomas\\_Sunday](http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/index.html#Thomas_Sunday)

<sup>7</sup> 1Peter 5:8 KJV "Be sober, be vigilant; because your adversary the devil, as a roaring lion, walketh about, seeking whom he may devour:"

<sup>8</sup> Cf. one of the stichera at Vespers: "When Thou didst enter, O Christ, while the doors were shut, / Thomas, who was called the Twin, was not with them. / Wherefore, he doubted what was told him, / thus by unbelief confirming his belief. / And Thou, O Good One, didst not disdain to show him / Thine immaculate side and the wounds of Thy hands and feet. / Wherefore, having felt and beheld, / he confessed that Thou art neither naked God nor mere man, // and he cried: O my Lord and my God, glory be to Thee."

<sup>9</sup> (Acts 5:15) Inasmuch that they brought forth the sick into the streets, and laid them on beds and couches, that at the least the shadow of Peter passing by might overshadow some of them.

<sup>10</sup> (John 20:19,24) Then the same day at evening, being the first day of the week, when the doors were shut where the disciples were assembled for fear of the Jews, came Jesus and stood in the midst, and saith unto them, Peace be unto you. ... {24} But Thomas, one of the twelve, called Didymus, was not with them when Jesus came.

<sup>11</sup> Judas was dead, Thomas was gone, and the replacement for Judas (Matthias) had not been elected yet. This leaves ten.

<sup>12</sup> John 20:20

<sup>13</sup> (John 20:1-8) The first day of the week cometh Mary Magdalene early, when it was yet dark, unto the sepulchre, and seeth the stone taken away from the sepulchre. {2} Then she runneth, and cometh to Simon Peter, and to the other disciple, whom Jesus loved, and saith unto them, They have taken away the Lord out of the sepulchre, and we know not where they have laid him. {3} Peter therefore went forth, and that other disciple, and came to the sepulchre. {4} So they ran both together: and the other disciple did outrun Peter, and came first to the sepulchre. {5} And he stooping down, and looking in, saw the linen clothes lying; yet went he not in. {6} Then cometh Simon Peter following him, and went into the sepulchre, and seeth the linen clothes lie, {7} And the napkin, that was about his head, not lying with the linen clothes, but wrapped together in a place by itself. {8} Then went in also that other disciple, which came first to the sepulchre, and he saw, and believed.

<sup>14</sup> (Luke 24:10-12) It was Mary Magdalene, and Joanna, and Mary the mother of James, and other women that were with them, which told these things unto the apostles. {11} And their words seemed to them as idle tales, and they believed them not. {12} Then arose Peter, and ran unto the sepulchre; and stooping down, he beheld the linen clothes laid by themselves, and departed, wondering in himself at that which was come to pass.

<sup>15</sup> (John 20:11-16) But Mary stood without at the sepulchre weeping: and as she wept, she stooped down, and looked into the sepulchre, {12} And seeth two angels in white sitting, the one at the head, and the other at the feet, where the body of Jesus had lain. {13} And they say unto her, Woman, why weepest thou? She saith unto them, Because they have taken away my Lord, and I know not where they have laid him. {14} And when she had thus said, she turned herself back, and saw Jesus standing, and knew not that it was Jesus. {15} Jesus saith unto her, Woman, why weepest thou? whom seekest thou? She, supposing him to be the gardener, saith unto him, Sir, if thou have borne him hence, tell me where thou hast laid him, and I will take him away. {16} Jesus saith unto her, Mary. She turned herself, and saith unto him, Rabboni; which is to say, Master.

<sup>16</sup> Ibid.

<sup>17</sup> Luke 24:13-33

<sup>18</sup> We understand this from holy tradition, and the scripture: (Luke 24:33-35) And they rose up the same hour, and returned to Jerusalem, and found the eleven gathered together, and them that were with them, {34} Saying, The Lord is risen indeed, and hath appeared to Simon. {35} And they told what things were done in the way, and how he was known of them in breaking of bread.

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<sup>19</sup> Cf. (John 20:27) Then saith he to Thomas, Reach hither thy finger, and behold my hands; and reach hither thy hand, and thrust it into my side: and be not faithless, but believing.

<sup>20</sup> John 20:28

<sup>21</sup> The Symbol of faith is also known as the "Nicene Creed".

<sup>22</sup> The Sunday of the Myrhbearers is the 3rd Sunday of Pascha (counting Pascha as the 1st Sunday of Pascha)

<sup>23</sup> The Samaritan Woman, whom the church knows as St Photini (5th Sunday of Pascha)

<sup>24</sup> Cf. John 11, and especially (John 11:23-26) Jesus saith unto her, Thy brother shall rise again. {24} Martha saith unto him, I know that he shall rise again in the resurrection at the last day. {25} Jesus said unto her, I am the resurrection, and the life: he that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live: {26} And whosoever liveth and believeth in me shall never die. Believest thou this?

<sup>25</sup> (John 21:25) And there are also many other things which Jesus did, the which, if they should be written every one, I suppose that even the world itself could not contain the books that should be written. Amen.

<sup>26</sup> John 20:21

<sup>27</sup> John 21:11

<sup>28</sup> Cf. John 21:15-19

<sup>29</sup> The Epiclesis occurs during the Anaphora, which is the time when the gifts of bread and wine are offered up, and the celebrant begs the Holy Spirit to transform them into the body and blood of Christ. The Greek word "Epiclesis" means "invocation" or "calling down from on high", and is the part of the Liturgy that occurs when the people are singing slowly: "We praise thee, we bless thee, we give thanks unto Thee, O Lord, and we pray unto Thee, O our God".

You can know that it has ended when a hymn to the Theotokos is sung. Here is an edited transcript of what occurs in the liturgy during this time:

The Priest says aloud: **Take, eat: this is my Body which is broken for you, for the remission of sins. And Drink of it, all of you: this is My Blood of the New Testament, which is shed for you and for many, for the remission of sins. and Thine own of Thine own we offer unto Thee, in behalf of all, and for all.**

At this point in the liturgy is another good time to offer up your secret prayers for the people that matter the most to you. This is been suggested by certain modern fathers, and it is good advice. I always pause for a moment and remember the people that are on my heart at this time as well as at the end.

The people are singing: **We praise thee, we bless thee, we give thanks unto Thee, O Lord, and we pray unto Thee, O our God.**

During this time the priest is invoking the Holy Spirit and begging that He change the gifts offered, the bread and wine, into the body and blood of Christ.

At the end, the priest exclaims aloud: **Especially for our most holy, most pure, most blessed, glorious Lady Theotokos and Ever-Virgin Mary.**

At this time, in most liturgies served during the year, the following hymn is sung: **It is truly meet to bless thee, the Theotokos, ever blessed and most blameless, and mother of our God. More honorable than the Cherubim, and beyond compare more glorious than the Seraphim, who without corruption gavest birth to God the Word, the Very Theotokos: thee do we magnify.**

This is the time referred to in this homily, a holy time to put forth your most deep desires to the Lord. It is good to have a list if you have trouble remembering, and pray simply, and forcefully: "Lord have mercy on \_\_\_\_". **This is a holy moment; DON'T miss it!**

<sup>30</sup> Cf. Matthew 20:30

<sup>31</sup> Cf. John 19:35, paraphrased.